



Dream factory: A glimpse of the facilities at the HPCA residential academy, where Pawan Sen is shaping the next generation of women cricketers dreaming of wearing India colours one day. R. V. MOORTHY

parents saw how the team played in that final. They knew Sushma's parents, who sent them to me. I initially sent them back. I said we take in just girls from Himachal Pradesh. But they were able to convince me. Harleen impressed me with her bowling too, and she joined in 2011," Sen says.

In 2013, Sushma got a call-up to the T20 side to face Bangladesh. The following year, she was picked for the ODI team and went on to represent India at the 2017 ODI World Cup.

"Sushma played first, and that inspired all the others to dream bigger," Sen beams.

"Before that academy started, I don't think most girls knew that they could play cricket on such a platform. Sushma di played for India first. After that, all of us, me, Renuka,

and all of us. If there were no academy, none of us would have been able to reach that stage," Tanuja says. Sen had to wait six years before another one of his students broke into the national set-up. Harleen earned her India cap in 2019, while Renuka followed in 2021. In 2024, Tanuja became the fourth student to represent India.

"Renuka in 2019 was the second-highest wicket-taker in one-days and still did not get a call-up to India. She was so frustrated at that time. I simply gave her the example of Cheteshwar Pujara. He scored 1000 runs for two consecutive seasons to get in. I told her to repeat that performance. The same was the case with Tanuja Kanwer.

"Nooshin Al Khadeer conducted a camp here. I asked her that Tanuja

has been bowling so well for the last three years; what more does she need to do to get into the Indian team? She said that you've been patient for so long; just keep it that way for six more months; she's about to break in. Three months later, she got the call," Sen says.

Tanuja will tour England next month with the India-A side. Harleen will also be part of that squad. For Renuka, there is a bigger goal. She will be part of India's T20 World Cup squad in England next month.

Back in Nagrota, Sen awaits the next month with eager anticipation. But for him, success is more than just seeing his students compete internationally. It lies in knowing that cricket has now reached Himachal's grassroots, where girls no longer have to ask what they will gain by picking up a cricket bat.